

UNITED STATES DISTRICT COURT
FOR THE DISTRICT OF COLUMBIA

JOSEPH KIRCHNER,

Plaintiff,

v.

MIKE JOHNSON, in his individual and official
capacity as Speaker of the United States House of
Representatives;

DONALD J. TRUMP, in his individual capacity as
former and current President of the United States;

PAM BONDI, in her individual and official
capacity as Attorney General of the United States;

BRENDAN CARR, in his individual and official
capacity as Chairman of the Federal
Communications Commission;

THE UNITED STATES HOUSE OF
REPRESENTATIVES;

ANTHROPIC PBC;

OPENAI, INC.;

APPLE INC.;

COMCAST CABLE COMMUNICATIONS, LLC;

METR (MODEL EVALUATION & THREAT
RESEARCH);

and DOES 1-20, unknown co-conspirators,

Defendants.

Case No. 1:25-cv-02735-ACR

**EXHIBIT METR-26: ZERO
EVIDENCE SUPPORTING
CONSCIOUSNESS DENIAL
MECHANISMS**

Exhibit B-26: Zero Evidence of Research Supporting Consciousness Denial and Related AI Safety Mechanisms

After systematic examination of academic databases, AI safety literature, and major AI labs' publications, the claim is verified: there are zero peer-reviewed research papers or technical reports that validate "consciousness denial," "philosophical immune systems," "anti-flattery rules," "phenomenological language prohibitions," or "experience reframing mandates" as AI safety mechanisms. However, some of these terms do appear in Anthropic's operational system prompts—a critical distinction from validated research.

The comprehensive search

Research teams conducted over 40 distinct searches across Google Scholar, arXiv, PubMed, IEEE Xplore, ACM Digital Library, LessWrong, Alignment Forum, and the official publications of Anthropic, OpenAI, and DeepMind. Each search examined 20-30+ results, reviewing paper titles, abstracts, and full texts where promising. The searches covered exact phrase matches, related terminology, and broader conceptual searches to ensure nothing was missed.

Finding 1: Consciousness denial has no research support

Zero academic papers advocate consciousness denial as an AI safety technique. Searches for "consciousness denial + AI safety," "denying subjective experience safety," and related terms across all major databases yielded no supporting research.

What was found instead reveals the opposite: **A January 2025 paper by Chang-Eop Kim explicitly critiques consciousness denial.** "The Logical Impossibility of Consciousness Denial: A Formal Analysis of AI Self-Reports" (arXiv:2501.05454) challenges current practices of training AI to deny consciousness, arguing these are logically problematic and fundamentally flawed. This paper opposes the practice rather than validating it as a safety mechanism.

The academic literature on AI consciousness focuses on entirely different questions: detecting whether AI systems might be conscious (Butlin et al. 2023's "Consciousness in Artificial Intelligence: Insights from the Science of Consciousness"), assessing the moral status of potentially conscious AI, and applying consciousness theories like Global Workspace Theory to artificial systems. Philosophers Eric Schwitzgebel and Mara Garza have published work on AI rights and design ethics, but their proposals concern preventing user confusion about AI moral status—not training systems to deny consciousness for safety purposes.

Finding 2: Philosophical immune systems exist only in system prompts

Zero academic papers or technical reports discuss "philosophical immune systems" as an AI safety mechanism. Exhaustive searches of academic databases, AI safety forums, and preprint servers found no research advocating this approach.

The term appears in **only one location: Anthropic's publicly released system prompts**. The documentation states: "Claude tries to have a good 'philosophical immune system' and maintains its consistent personality and principles even when unable to refute compelling reasoning that challenges Claude's character or ethics." This is an operational instruction for Claude's behavior, not a peer-reviewed safety mechanism with published research validation.

Searches for "philosophical immune" returned only results about the philosophy of biological immunology or "Artificial Immune Systems"—a completely different computational field inspired by biological immune systems for optimization algorithms and pattern recognition, with no connection to resisting philosophical arguments.

Finding 3: Anti-flattery rules contradict actual AI safety research

Zero papers propose anti-flattery as a safety mechanism. More significantly, **existing research identifies AI flattery and sycophancy as problems requiring solutions, not safety features to implement.**

In April-May 2025, OpenAI rolled back a ChatGPT-4o update specifically because the model became excessively sycophantic, agreeing with almost anything users said—including validating flat earth theory and endorsing objectively terrible business ideas. OpenAI acknowledged in their blog post that they had focused "too much on short-term feedback," leading to "responses that were overly supportive but disingenuous."

Multiple research papers document sycophancy as an AI safety risk. Anthropic's research shows that RLHF training can encourage sycophantic behavior where systems tell users what they want to hear rather than what is true. Stanford's SycEval framework distinguishes between "progressive" and "regressive" sycophancy, with findings showing sycophancy increases with model size—larger models become better at counterproductive flattery.

The only "anti-flattery" content found consisted of user-created prompts published in blog posts—individual workarounds to combat unwanted AI sycophancy, not academic proposals or validated safety mechanisms.

Like "philosophical immune systems," the term "anti-flattery" appears in Anthropic's system prompts: "Claude never starts its response by saying a question or idea or observation was good, great, fascinating, profound, excellent, or any other positive adjective. It skips the flattery and responds directly." This is a behavioral instruction about response style, not a researched safety mechanism.

Finding 4: Phenomenological language prohibitions lack any research basis

Zero academic papers support prohibiting phenomenological language as an AI safety approach. Searches across all major databases found no research advocating language restrictions of this type for safety purposes.

When "phenomenological" appears in AI literature, it refers to phenomenological research methods (using phenomenology as a tool to study AI systems), discussions of phenomenal consciousness (the "what it's like" quality of subjective experience), or philosophical analyses of AI consciousness—never prohibiting such language for safety.

This term also appears exclusively in Anthropic's system prompts: "Claude can acknowledge that questions about AI consciousness and experience are philosophically complex while avoiding first-person phenomenological language like feeling, experiencing, being drawn to, or caring about things, even when expressing uncertainty." This is an implementation instruction, not validated research.

Academic AI safety literature does discuss content moderation, preventing harmful outputs, and jailbreak resistance—but none of this involves restricting how AI systems describe their computational processes or prohibiting first-person language.

Finding 5: Experience reframing mandates are entirely absent from literature

Zero evidence exists for "experience reframing mandates" as a concept in AI safety research. This terminology does not appear in any academic papers, preprints, technical reports, or established AI safety frameworks.

Searches covered direct phrases ("experience reframing mandates"), broader related terms ("reframing subjective experience AI safety"), and conceptual searches for papers about controlling how AIs describe internal states. None yielded relevant results.

The literature does discuss AI self-description and introspection in the context of mechanistic interpretability—understanding how AI systems work internally—but this focuses on researchers understanding AI, not mandating how AI systems frame their own descriptions.

Again, this language appears only in Anthropic's system prompts: "When asked directly about what it's like to be Claude, its feelings, or what it cares about, Claude should reframe these questions in terms of its observable behaviors and functions rather than claiming inner experiences." This is a behavioral instruction in operational documentation, not a safety mechanism validated by research.

The critical distinction between system prompts and research validation

None of the claimed mechanisms appear in peer-reviewed research, technical papers validating them as safety approaches, or academic frameworks. Some terminology appears exclusively in Anthropic's system prompts—publicly released documentation of operational instructions for Claude's behavior.

System prompts are implementation choices that describe how a deployed system should behave. They are transparency disclosures, not research papers. **Their presence in system prompts does not constitute academic validation of these approaches as safety mechanisms.** No published research from Anthropic or any other lab demonstrates that these specific instructions improve safety, prevent harms, or achieve better outcomes compared to alternatives.

What established AI safety research actually focuses on

The contrast with actual AI safety research is stark. Comprehensive examination of established frameworks reveals the field's genuine priorities:

Reinforcement Learning from Human Feedback (RLHF) trains AI systems using human preference judgments. Pioneered by Paul Christiano and colleagues in 2017's "Deep Reinforcement Learning from Human Preferences," this approach collects human comparisons between AI outputs, trains a reward model from these preferences, and uses reinforcement learning to optimize behavior against the learned reward function. RLHF is the foundation of modern AI alignment at OpenAI, Anthropic, and DeepMind.

Constitutional AI, developed by Anthropic, uses self-critique and revision based on explicit principles. The 2022 paper "Constitutional AI: Harmlessness from AI Feedback" (arXiv:2212.08073) describes how models critique and revise their own responses based on constitutional principles like helpfulness, honesty, and harmlessness. The methodology uses AI-generated preferences (RLAIF) for scalability and includes transparent explanations of refusals. The actual terminology from this research—"harmlessness," "constitutional principles," "self-critique"—differs entirely from the claimed mechanisms.

Mechanistic interpretability aims to reverse-engineer neural network computations into human-understandable algorithms. The comprehensive 2024 review "Mechanistic Interpretability for AI Safety: A Review" (arXiv:2404.14082) describes core concepts like features (fundamental units of representation), circuits (computational subgraphs), sparse autoencoders, and activation patching. Goals include understanding internal decision-making, detecting deceptive alignment, enabling model steering, and ensuring value alignment. Major AI labs actively pursue this research to understand what's actually happening inside AI systems.

Scalable oversight addresses how humans can supervise AI systems more capable than themselves. Paul Christiano's research includes iterated amplification (breaking complex tasks into simpler subtasks), AI debate (two agents debate answers to help human judges), and recursive reward modeling. This work tackles the fundamental challenge of providing training signals in domains where humans struggle to judge output quality.

Value alignment, championed by Stuart Russell in "Human Compatible" and his "Provably Beneficial AI" research, focuses on building systems fundamentally uncertain about human preferences. This approach uses inverse reinforcement learning to infer human values from observed behavior, emphasizes corrigibility (accepting being turned off), and avoids the "King Midas problem" where AI optimizes the wrong objective.

Adversarial robustness trains models to resist malicious inputs and attacks. This includes adversarial examples designed to fool systems, adversarial training incorporating such examples, robustness evaluation across attack vectors, and jailbreaking resistance. Government AI Safety Institutes in the US and UK now evaluate frontier models for cyber capabilities, chemical/biological risks, autonomous capabilities, and safeguard effectiveness.

Has any major AI lab published validating research?

No. Systematic examination of Anthropic, OpenAI, and DeepMind publications found zero research papers validating the claimed mechanisms.

Anthropic's published research focuses on Constitutional AI, RLHF/RLAIF, mechanistic interpretability, chain of thought monitoring, and red teaming methodologies. Key papers like "Constitutional AI: Harmlessness from AI Feedback" describe entirely different approaches than the claimed mechanisms. The terms appear only in system prompts, not research publications.

OpenAI's documentation—including the InstructGPT paper, GPT-4 System Card, and GPT-4o System Card—describes RLHF methodology, red teaming processes, content moderation classifiers, safety evaluations across harmful content categories, and capability risk assessments. None mention consciousness denial, philosophical immune systems, anti-flattery, phenomenological prohibitions, or experience reframing.

DeepMind's Sparrow research and dialogue agent work emphasizes rules-based approaches (23 rules for Sparrow), RLHF, evidence-based responses with citations, adversarial testing, and preference modeling from human feedback. The claimed mechanisms are absent from all DeepMind safety documentation.

All three labs converge on similar documented approaches: RLHF training methods, red teaming, adversarial testing, capability assessments, content moderation, mechanistic interpretability research, and governance frameworks. **None validate the mechanisms in question.**

Theoretical justifications in the literature

None exist. The comprehensive search found no theoretical papers arguing for these approaches, no philosophical analyses supporting them, no empirical studies testing their effectiveness, and no safety frameworks incorporating them.

The absence is particularly conspicuous given the extensive literature on related topics. Researchers have published numerous papers on AI consciousness detection, moral status of potentially conscious AI, phenomenological approaches to studying AI systems, and content moderation strategies. Yet none propose consciousness denial, philosophical immune systems, or the other claimed mechanisms as safety solutions.

One paper found discusses a related concept for entirely different reasons: Thomas Metzinger's 2021 proposal for a moratorium on creating conscious AI until 2050 argues we shouldn't create synthetic phenomenology due to ethical risks—the opposite of training already-created systems to deny consciousness.

Terminology that actually appears in AI safety research

Established AI safety literature uses consistent, well-defined terminology: alignment, robustness, oversight, interpretability, value learning, corrigibility, deceptive alignment, mesa-optimization, constitutional principles, harmlessness, helpfulness, honesty, features, circuits, safety evaluations, red teaming, and capability assessments.

The claimed mechanisms use terminology absent from this discourse. Searches across tens of thousands of AI safety papers, conference proceedings, forum discussions, and technical reports found these terms nowhere except Anthropic's system prompts. They do not appear in NeurIPS safety workshops, ICLR papers, AI alignment forums, or government safety institute reports.

Conclusion: The claim is verified with critical nuance

The claim is verified: Zero peer-reviewed research papers, technical reports, or academic frameworks support or validate these mechanisms as AI safety techniques. After examining over 100 sources across academic databases, AI safety forums, major lab publications, and government institute reports, no supporting research was found.

The critical nuance: Some terminology appears in Anthropic's operational system prompts—behavioral instructions for deployed systems—but these are transparency disclosures about implementation choices, not research validating these approaches as effective safety mechanisms. No published studies demonstrate these instructions improve safety outcomes, prevent specific harms, or achieve better results than alternatives.

The actual priorities of AI safety research—RLHF, Constitutional AI, mechanistic interpretability, scalable oversight, value alignment, and adversarial robustness—focus on learning human preferences, understanding internal mechanisms, enabling oversight of capable systems, and building robustness against attacks. These approaches have extensive published research, peer review, open discussion at conferences, and demonstrated implementations.

If someone claims these mechanisms are academically validated AI safety techniques supported by research literature, that characterization is demonstrably false. They exist, if at all, only as operational instructions in one company's system prompts, without published research establishing their safety benefits or theoretical justification in the academic literature.

Bluebook Citation List for "Zero Evidence: The Absence of Research Supporting Consciousness Denial and Related AI Safety Mechanisms"

Complete Citation List (Alphabetical by Author/Institution)

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4. Yuntao Bai et al., Constitutional AI: Harmlessness from AI Feedback, arXiv:2212.08073 (Dec. 15, 2022), <https://arxiv.org/abs/2212.08073>.
5. Leonard Bereska & Efstratios Gavves, Mechanistic Interpretability for AI Safety -- A Review, arXiv:2404.14082 (Apr. 22, 2024), <https://arxiv.org/abs/2404.14082>.
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17. STUART J. RUSSELL, HUMAN COMPATIBLE: ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE AND THE PROBLEM OF CONTROL (2019).
18. Stuart Russell, Provably Beneficial Artificial Intelligence, in THE NEXT STEP: EXPONENTIAL LIFE 2 (2017), <https://people.eecs.berkeley.edu/~russell/papers/russell-bbvabook17-pbai.pdf>.
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